
THE UNCONVENTIONAL WEEKLY

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UNCONVENTIONAL NEUROSCIENTISTS



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SAM ALTMAN-BACKED MERGE LABS TARGETS AMBITIOUS NEXT-GEN BCI

Breakthrough alert: Sam Altman-backed startup stirs excitement with ambitious plans and strong funding to develop high-speed brain-computer interfaces, hinting at a bold new future for human-AI interaction.

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What's Happening?

Merge Labs, a recently announced startup co-founded by Sam Altman (CEO of OpenAI & Co-Founder of Tools for Humanity) and Alex Blania (CEO of Tools for Humanity & Co-Founder of Worldcoin) and reportedly backed by OpenAI's venture arm, is generating intense buzz in the neurotech space. Sources suggest that their approach may involve a combination of:

- 🧬 Gene therapy to modify brain cells
- 🔊 Ultrasound technology to non-invasively modulate those cells

This speculative combination could enable more precise and less invasive brain interfaces than existing technologies, potentially paving the way for entirely new modes of interacting with AI systems.

Why It Matters?

Scientific Perspective?

High-speed BCIs could transform human-computer interaction, enabling seamless brain-digital integration. Merge Labs' gene therapy and ultrasound method could modulate neurons without bulky implants, unlocking applications from medical interventions to cognitive augmentation. Compared to traditional electrode-based BCIs, this approach is higher fidelity, safer, and less intrusive.

Conceptual Perspective?

The evolution of interfaces has roughly followed this path: punch cards, GUIs, touchscreens, voice, and now BCIs. Merge Labs' approach could remove slow interaction, making interfaces feel less machine-like and advancing a fundamentally new interaction model. Merge is uniquely positioned to make this vision a reality because of its novel technology, ambitious scope, and backing by AI pioneers.

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Why It's Unconventional?

Merge Labs stands out because of its unprecedented early-stage hype and funding in neurotech. Raising \$250 million at an \$850 million valuation with no publicly disclosed product is unheard of. For comparison:

🧠 Synchron: ~\$400–450M

🧠 Precision Neuroscience: ~\$500M

🧠 Neuralink: ~\$9B (widely criticized for overvaluation)

Early funding and attention show that investors are betting on vision and human potential, not just technology. Merge Labs also raises important ethical, privacy, and safety questions, since high-bandwidth BCIs provide unprecedented access to human cognition. With this spotlight, Merge Labs could push neurotech into the mainstream, sparking discussions about what's possible and how society should prepare.

What's your **Unconventional** Take?

How should society regulate and protect access to our thoughts and cognition?

If BCIs go mainstream, what new ethical, social, and legal challenges will arise?

Is the buzz around Merge Labs a glimpse of transformative innovation, or just another cycle of tech hype?

